

A TREATMENT TRIAL OF ACUPUNCTURE IN IBS PATIENTS

.

Objective To compare the effects of true and sham acupuncture in relieving symptoms of IBS. **Methods** A total of 230 adult IBS patients (75% females, average age 38.4 yrs) were randomly assigned to 3 weeks of true or sham acupuncture (6 treatments) following a 3 week 'run-in' with sham acupuncture in an 'augmented' or 'limited' patient-practitioner interaction. A third arm of the study included a waitlist control group. The primary outcome was the IBS Global Improvement Scale (IBS-GIS) (range 1–7); secondary outcomes included IBS Symptom Severity Scale (IBS-SSS), Adequate Relief (IBS-AR) and IBS-Quality of life (IBS-QOL). **Results** Though there was no statistically significant difference between acupuncture and sham acupuncture on the IBS-GIS (41% vs. 32%, $p=0.25$), both groups improved significantly compared to the wait list control group (37% vs. 4%, $p=0.001$). Similarly, small differences that were not statistically significant favored acupuncture on the other three outcomes: IBS-AR (59% vs 57%, $p=0.83$), IBS-SSS (31% vs 21%, $p=0.18$) and IBS-QOL (17% vs 13%, $p=0.56$). Eliminating responders during the run-in period did not substantively change the results. Side effects were generally mild and only slightly greater in the acupuncture group. **Conclusion** This study did not find evidence to support the superiority of acupuncture compared to sham acupuncture in the treatment of IBS.